

Enhancing Regional Security
Frameworks in the Middle East with
Emphasis on the Regulation of Arm
Importations

Disarmament and International Security (First Committee)

I. Introduction

The Middle East has been facing political instability for long, remaining one of the most militarized regions in the world. At the root of ongoing conflicts in the region lie extremely complex geopolitical dynamics built on years of rivalries and hostilities. Thus, the Middle East is faced with a continuous need for arm imports from political allies and although such aid is necessary for national defense, it is also poorly controlled.

The lack of regulations regarding the importation of weapons is one of the factors which contributes to the escalation of conflicts and the intensification of crises. Non-state actors are profiting off of the lack of proper monitorization in the area and, despite having an important role, external powers end up complicating regional relations by supplying arms in such an unregulated manner.

In order to prevent the further amplification of conflicts and promote stability in the Middle East, it is essential to strengthen security frameworks and implement stricter regulations regarding arm importations in the region.

II. Definition of Key Terms

Arms Importation

The transfer of weapons, ammunition, and military equipment from a supplier in a foreign country to a recipient across national borders for purposes such as national defense;

Arms Proliferation

The rapid and uncontrolled spread of military equipment, across countries and to actors who did not previously possess them;

Non-State Actors

Groups or individuals with significant political influence, but which are not affiliated with any government, such as terrorist organizations, insurgent groups, NGOs, and multinational corporations.

III. Background Information

The dependency of Middle Eastern nations on foreign military equipment can be traced back to the mid-20th century, having great ties with the Cold War. During this period, global superpowers such as the United States and the Soviet Union supplied weapons to regional allies to expand their influence. After the War ended, western countries joined in on the trade and the regional arms market became more diversified. Moreover, conflicts such as the Iran-Iraq war, or the ongoing fight between Israel and Arab nations, strengthened the need for military enforcement and the idea that the implication of external powers is essential for survival.

What the Middle East is currently facing could be described as a security dilemma. When one state takes actions to increase its security, others feel threatened and respond in a similar manner. This creates a vicious cycle of constant accumulation of military capabilities, which ultimately further destabilizes the region.

The ongoing geopolitical rivalries within the area, such as the competition between Iran and Saudi Arabia for regional dominance, or the tensions involving Israel and neighboring states contribute to constant military build-up.

Active conflicts in countries such as Syria, Yemen, and Iraq have significantly increased the demand for imported arms, and while the governments of the involved states rely on external suppliers to sustain military operations, weapons often reach non-state actors. For instance, in Yemen, arms supplied to state actors have reportedly been diverted to armed groups, similarly to the Syrian civil war in which different factions have received supplies from international actors. In cases like these, the lack of solid security frameworks and monitorization are complicating the conflicts and prolonging instability.

External powers play a crucial role in shaping conflicts the Middle East through arm importation according to political ties. Countries such as the United States, Russia, and European nations provide military equipment, internationalizing the conflicts and protecting strategic interests. The US is known for supplying Israel and Saudi Arabia, while Russia provides arms to allies such as Syria and Iran.

Despite the existence of international agreements such as the Arms Trade Treaty (ATT), enforcement remains inconsistent in the Middle East. Regulations are not being implemented effectively and the international community still faces lack of transparency regarding deals.

Non-state actors frequently acquire illicit arms through smuggling networks and black markets. Militant groups such as ISIS often obtain and use advanced weaponry captured from state stockpiles or supplied indirectly. This not only threatens regional stability but also poses a global security risk.

The consequences of unregulated arms importation are affecting much more than military dynamics. Because of weapon proliferation there are higher civilian casualties and displaced populations. Prolonged conflicts and instability mean prolonged human rights violations. Thus, there is a rising need for regulations and monitorization.

IV. Major Countries and Organizations Involved

Saudi Arabia

Saudi Arabia relies heavily on weapon imports from the United States and European nations, being one of the world's largest importers of arms. Its strategic goal of maintaining regional dominance and countering Iranian influence. Its military expenses have significantly increased over the past decade, its goal being that of maintaining regional dominance by countering Iranian efforts.

The nation has faced international criticism over the use of imported weapons in Yemen, particularly concerning civilian casualties and alleged violations of international humanitarian law.

Iran

While it is not a major arms importer compared to Gulf states, Iran plays a complex role in regional security dynamics. The country has faced accusations of supplying proxy groups across the Middle East, such as militias in Iraq, Hezbollah in Lebanon, and the Houthis in Yemen.

By building a strong arms industry, Iran manages to use transfers to non-state actors to expand its regional influence without engaging in direct conflict.

Israel

Israel's military force is one of the most technologically advanced in the region. The nation has a dual role, being both an importer of cyber warfare and high-tech systems, particularly from the United States, but also a major exporter of arms and defense technologies.

United Arab Emirates (UAE)

In recent years, the UAE has been actively involved in regional conflicts, particularly in Yemen and Libya, and has supported various non-state actors. As a result, it has invested heavily in modernizing its armed forces, purchasing advanced aircraft, drones, and missile systems. Currently, the UAE is aiming to reduce reliance on foreign suppliers and develop its domestic industry.

United States

The United States is the largest arms exporter to the Middle East and plays a central role in shaping regional security dynamics. The U.S. supports key allies such as Saudi Arabia, Israel, and the UAE. The United States views arms transfers as necessary for maintaining regional stability and countering threats such as terrorism, despite the accusations that arms exports have actually contributed to the escalation of conflicts.

Russia

The Russian Federation is a major arms supplier in the region, especially to countries such as Syria and Iran. Regarding conflicts in Syria, Russia has had direct military intervention and has also provided advanced weaponry.

Russia is an attractive partner for states facing international restrictions since it often imposes fewer conditions on arms sales than most western nations.

France

In the second half of the 20th century, France joined Britain in their support for Israel, which caused Arab states to break ties with the country until De Gaulle started actively working towards bettering the relations with the Middle East. Moreover, the hostility between France and Israel increased, as the state urged the UN to contribute to mediate the Arab-Israeli dispute.

Israel has recently decided to halt arm imports from France.

China

China provides relatively low-cost weapons and has therefore become a significant player in the Middle Eastern arms trade. The PRC's exports are appealing to countries seeking alternatives to western suppliers, and have contributed to widening involvement in regional conflicts.

The League of Arab States (LAS) and the Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC)

These regional organizations aim to promote cooperation among Arab countries and coordinate defense policies. Their effectiveness regarding unified action on arms regulation remains limited due to divisions between national interests.

V. Timeline of Events

Date	Description of event
1948	The establishment of Israel and the start of a prolonged regional conflict
1980-1988	Iran-Iraq War significantly increases arms imports
2003	Iraq war leads to arms proliferation and increases already present regional instability
2011	Arab Spring triggers the beginning of conflicts in Libya, Syria and Yemen
2015	Conflicts in Yemen escalate and arms imports fester
2020s	Rise in arm imports and proxy conflicts in the region

VI. Relevant UN Treaties and Events

- **Arms Trade Treaty (ATT) (2014)**
- **UN Security Council Resolution 1540 (2004)**
- **UN Security Council Resolution 2220 (2015)**
- **UN Register of Conventional Arms (UNROCA) - The key international mechanism for states to report on international arms transfers.**

VII. Previous Attempts to Solve the Issues

- **International Treaties and Legal Frameworks**

Treaties such as the Arms Trade Treaty (ATT) and frameworks like the UN Register of Conventional Arms (UNROCA), aim to establish international standards for the import and export of conventional weapons and promote transparency regarding the monitorization of arm transfers, with the goal of preventing weapons from reaching actors who may use them to violate human rights. However, not all significant actors are signatories or abide the regulations. The inconsistent participation from the Middle East reduces the impact of the international community.

Regarding legal frameworks for exports, major actors have implemented national or international export control systems to regulate the sale of weapons. For example, member states of the European Union follow the EU Common Position on arms exports.

- **UN Arms Embargoes**

The United Nations Security Council has previously imposed bans on arm trades on countries in the Middle East, including Iran, Libya, and Yemen, in an effort to limit the flow of weapons into conflict zones. Despite efforts, there have been instances where official restrictions were bypassed. For example, in Libya and Yemen, arms embargoes have been widely violated and weapons have continued to reach various factions.

- **Security Initiatives**

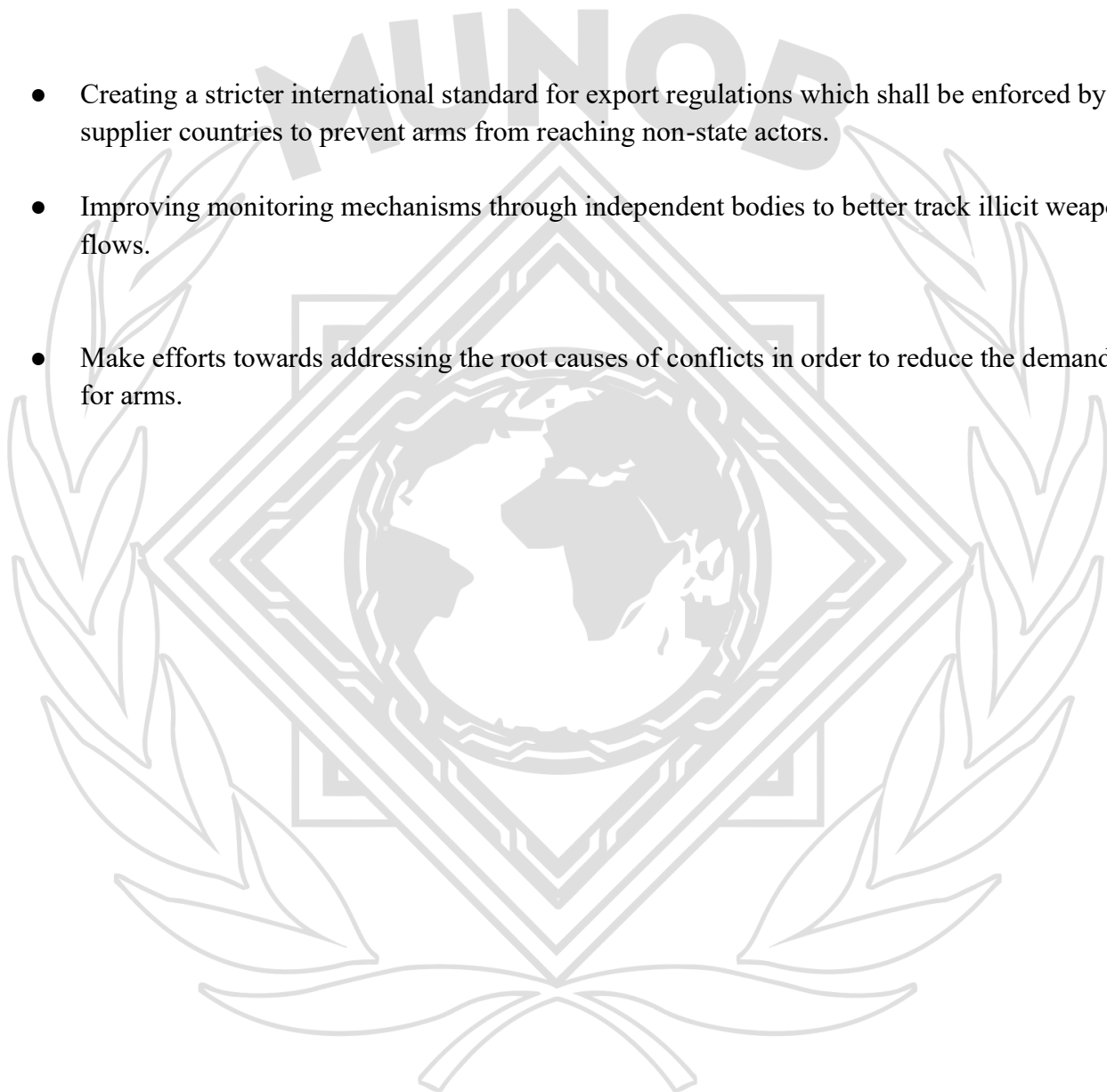
Efforts to enhance security frameworks in the Middle East have been limited by the lack of cooperation between states. Organizations such as the League of Arab States (LAS) and the Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) have attempted to coordinate defense and security policies, but have encountered political divisions among countries.

- **Non-Proliferation Efforts**

There have been multiple initiatives involving border security and tracking, aimed to prevent illicit weapon flows. UN Security Council resolutions, such as Resolution 1540, focus on preventing the proliferation of weapons to terrorist groups. However, there is a need for stronger controls, since non-state actors continue to acquire arms through black markets and diverting stockpiles.

VIII. Possible Solutions

- Strengthening regional cooperation by establishing a Middle East security forum to improve border control, especially in regards to arm tracking.
- Implementing the mandatory reporting of arms imports and exports to international bodies in order to enhance transparency.
- Creating a stricter international standard for export regulations which shall be enforced by supplier countries to prevent arms from reaching non-state actors.
- Improving monitoring mechanisms through independent bodies to better track illicit weapon flows.
- Make efforts towards addressing the root causes of conflicts in order to reduce the demand for arms.



IX. Sources

- <https://main.un.org/securitycouncil/en/content/repertoire/middle-east>
- <https://www.sipri.org/commentary/topical-backgroundunder/2025/recent-trends-international-arms-transfers-middle-east-and-north-africa>
- <https://www.bbc.com/news/topics/cnq8l222v07t>
- <https://www.un.org/disarmament/armstradetreaty/>
- <https://www.unroca.org/>
- United Nations Security Council Resolution 1540 (2004) - <https://www.un.org/en/sc/1540/>
- United Nations Security Council Resolution 2220 (2015) - [https://docs.un.org/en/S/RES/2220\(2015\)](https://docs.un.org/en/S/RES/2220(2015))
- Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) - <https://www.gcc-sg.org/>
- League of Arab States (LAS) - <http://www.lasportal.org/>

